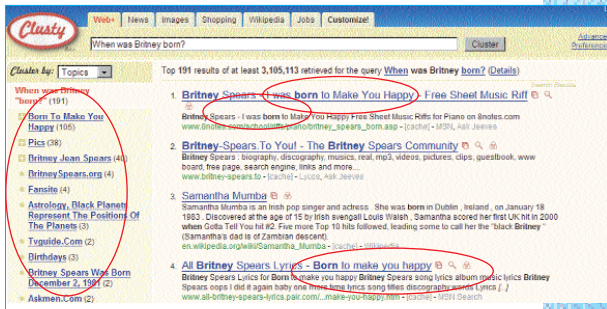




Clusty's clusters—on the left—are often useful, but when we asked it when Britney was born, *Born to make you happy* dominated the results

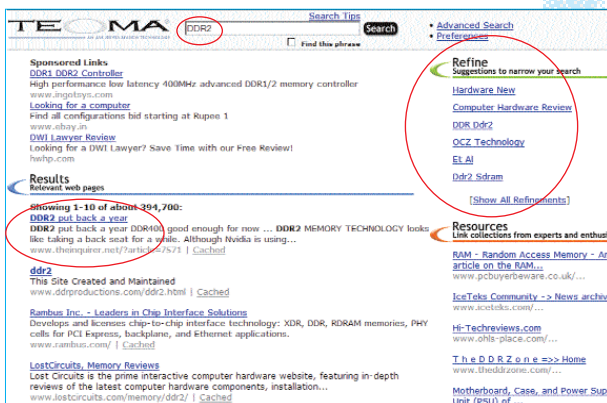
has already been implemented by several smaller search engines such as Vivisimo's Clusty, but the other major search engines (including Google) will likely soon follow."

And here's a quote from Tony Philipp, executive VP of Vivisimo: "The challenge that you have right now is not information overload. It's information overlook."

Authority

You might be familiar with a popular alternative search engine out there called Teoma. Although 'Authority' isn't a word one would normally associate with search engines, Teoma's selling point is its Authority rankings. As they claim: "The Teoma difference is authority. A lot of the players in the ever-evolving search space talk about relevance. But what do they really do to achieve this Holy Grail? And what do they offer to prove their claims? The truth is, not much. Teoma has invented a whole new approach to search, and this allows us to achieve our mission of providing the best search results on the Web... Teoma adds a new dimension and level of authority to search results through its breakthrough approach, known as Subject-Specific Popularity."

"Instead of ranking results based upon the sites with the most links leading to them, Teoma analyses the Web as it is organically organised—in naturally-occurring communities that are about the same subject... To determine the authority—and thus the overall quality and relevance—of a site's content, Teoma uses



We asked Teoma about DDR2. The first non-sponsored result is from a well-known publication. The 'Refine' options seem intelligent, too

Subject-Specific Popularity, which ranks a site based on the number of same-subject pages that reference it, not just general popularity."

So does it work? Are Teoma results really more relevant and useful than Google's? We threw "When was Britney born?" at it (again), and surprisingly, there was no link to the star's birth date in any of the top ten results. However, Teoma also has a 'Refine' feature that lets you zero in on what you want, and in the 'Refine' section, we found the following: 'Britney Spears Biography'; 'What Is Britney Spears' Brother's Name'; 'How Old Is Britney Spears'; 'Britney Spears Life'; and 'Britney Childhood'. Unfortunately, clicking 'How Old Is Britney Spears' and 'Britney Spears Life' didn't provide the answer either.

So what is Teoma good at? It doesn't seem to be too good at answering questions, as we've seen, but when you're looking for general information on a subject, Teoma brings up obscure results that are way down in the Google list—taking Google as the benchmark. For example, a Google search on 'DDR2' brought up product pages first; a Teoma search brought up an article from theinquirer.net, a popular site, as the first result. Close to the top was also a page from lostcircuits.com, a site we found was a good source for hardware news. Google or Teoma—it's your call!

SEO And The Ultimate Search Engine

Everything we've discussed so far—emergent semantics, LSI, AI, NLP, clustering, personalisation, authority ranking—are things that search engines already have experimented with, or will soon experiment with. Who does what first is what matters when it comes to competition in the search space. The ideal search engine is just something that brings as many of these techniques together as possible. It will feature personalisation; it will cluster your results...

The important thing is that search engine optimisation (SEO) (See box 'Search Engine Optimisation'), as it exists today, should become redundant. SEO is all the rage—just search for 'search engine optimisation' and you'll get an idea of how big the business really is. There are all those sites out there struggling to get noticed, to get to the top.

On the other hand, what do you want? You want the sites that are most relevant, authoritative, and popular, along with related sites that may bring related topics to your attention. Peoples' habits aren't going to change in a long while—we'll most likely continue with our limited keyword habits. So are your interests at conflict with that of the search engine optimisers?

It may seem so. Pages that are not search-engine friendly, but of more interest to you, will, as of today, appear below those that have been optimised. And that's not what you want. You—the information-seeker—want SEO to be redundant. That is also the ultimate goal of Google, or of any other search engine.

It's when SEO vanishes that we'll know that the ultimate search engine has arrived. Until then—happy Googling! ☑

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